

Statement of Work (SOW)
Conference Support Assistant and Travel Services
to Support ARS, AFM, FMAD
Travel Policy and Systems Branch (TPSB)

1.0 Scope:

ARS is focused on providing high quality, efficient and effective support services to its customers. During daily operations, specialized technical expertise to support these activities is required in the area of conference support. The Financial Management and Agreements Division (FMAD), Travel Policy and Systems Branch (TPSB) requires the support of a Conference Support Assistant. The contractor is responsible for preparing and reviewing conference packages, assisting with REE Annual Conference planning and reporting, and providing excellent customer service.

2.0 Deliverables and General/Technical Requirements:

Conference packages require screening and editing by the contractor. To prepare a conference package, the contractor is required to meet the following requirements:

- Able to review GSA travel schedules to determine per diem and lodging rates for the conference site
- Research city pair/governmental airfares and fares for other modes of transportation or retrieve information from the travel system for each attendee
- Research lodging tax, resort fees (if applicable)
- Perform simple Internet searches of the conference website to obtain registration fee information, agendas, and information on items included in the fee, such as food
- Possess good writing skills necessary to prepare questionnaires and memos based on information from the Agency's strategic plan and conference websites
- Obtain the National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA), Section 889 Certification for large meetings.

When reviewing packages for conferences sponsored or hosted by the Agency, the contractor should possess excellent analytical and critical thinking skills to ensure the accuracy of lodging rates, lodging taxes, per diem rates, and reasonableness of airfare, public transportation, miscellaneous expenses, etc. The contractor should also audit and verify data that appears inaccurate or erroneous. The contractor should be able to verify compliance with laws and regulations such as the Federal Acquisition Regulation, Principles of Appropriations Law, Federal Travel Regulations, Agriculture Travel

Regulations, and other policies as specified by the Government through the Travel Branch Chief.

The contractor will be trained to utilize the ARS conference system, Agriculture Travel Information System (ATIS), for updates with conference participants to prepare hundreds of conference packages and reports, such as the annual conference plan and the quarterly conference transparency report. The team follows a template, and the contractors are expected to assist with the plan development and reporting, but not create it on their own.

The contractor should have basic skills using Excel, SharePoint, Adobe Acrobat, and customer service tools, such as our customer service portal (AFMCSP) and ConcurGov.

3.0 Government Furnished Property, Equipment and Services:

The government will furnish all necessary IT hardware, software, and utilities for contractor use in performance of the duties outlined in this SOW.

4.0 Facilities:

The government will furnish the necessary workspace for the contractor staff to provide the support outlined in this SOW to include desk space, telephones, computers and other items necessary to maintain an office environment. Some of the office space that is provided may be shared space. Under remote working conditions, the contractor is responsible for workspace needs.

5.0 Period of Performance

The period of performance will be 1 year, Starting 04/10/26- 04/09/2027

6.0 Type of Contract:

The government anticipates award of a fixed price, labor hour contract.

7.0 Hours of Operation/Place of Performance:

The conference support assistant is responsible for performing the services between the hours of 7:30 am and 6:00 pm, in eight (8) hour shifts, Monday through Friday, except federal holidays or when the government facility is closed due to local or national emergencies, administrative closings, or similar government directed facility closings.

This task can be executed on-site at the following location:

USDA/ARS
George Washington Carver Center (GWCC)
5601 Sunnyside Ave.
Beltsville, MD 20705,
Parking is provided

or
Remotely from a home site

8.0 Special Qualifications

The conference support assistant must be qualified, vetted, and have proper training and certifications to perform the functions outlined in the SOW. The contractor is expected to provide a fully trained workforce to the government; therefore, personal development training costs and hours are not billable to the government, unless agreed upon by the government.

9.0 Contract Manager:

The contractor must provide a contract/program manager who shall be responsible for the performance of the work. The name of this individual, and an alternate who can act for the contractor when the contract manager is absent, must be designated in writing to the CO. The contract manager or alternate must have full authority to act for the contractor on all contract matters relating to the daily operations of the contract.

The contract manager will be responsible for ensuring the conference support assistant provides a finalized copy of each pay timesheet to the designated government representative(s), COR/branch chief, on the last day of each pay period throughout the contract period. This will allow for accurate completion of the contract invoice by government personnel.

10.0 Personnel Security Requirements

Contractor personnel must comply with USDA Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD-12), "Policy for a Common Identification Standard for Federal Employees and Contractors, and Federal Information Processing Standards Publication (FIPS PUB) 201, "Personal Identity Verification (PIV) of Federal Employees and Contractors. Although the information being processed through this service is not classified, the information is considered highly sensitive PII and must be protected accordingly. It is imperative that company personnel, such as Database Administrators, System Administrators, etc., or anyone who possibly could access the data being processed, have an appropriate level of background investigation on file. The company would be responsible for ensuring that only personnel possessing the appropriate level of background investigation were instrumentally involved with the data processed by this service.

48 CFR 3052.204-71 requires that everyone employed under a Federal contract shall be a citizen of the United States of America, or a non- U.S. citizen who has been lawfully admitted for permanent residence as evidenced by a Permanent Resident Card (USCIS I551). Any exceptions must be approved by the Director, Office of Homeland Security (OHS) or designee.

USDA requires government issued identification badges and display of them at all times while on the premises. Background investigations and fingerprinting are required for all government and Contractor employees. If the government receives an unsuitable report of any Contractor employee after review and processing of security background information, the Contractor will be advised immediately, and such employees shall not continue to work at USDA or be assigned work under this or any USDA contract. The Contractor shall replace such employees with a new employee within 30 days.

All contractor personnel attending meetings, answering government telephones, and working in other situations where their contractor status is not obvious to a third party are required to identify themselves as such to avoid creating an impression that they are government officials. They must also ensure that all documents or reports produced by the contractor are suitably marked as contractor products or that contractor participation is appropriately disclosed.

The Contractor shall ensure that all Contractor employee identification badges are returned to USDA if employees are dismissed, when the contract expires, or whichever comes first. The government will have and exercise full and complete control over granting or denying of identification cards or other required security identification badges. It shall be the Contractor's responsibility to account for all identification cards/badges issued to Contractor personnel. Final Contractor payment will be withheld until all identification cards and security identification badges, as well as keys or other government assigned items, have been accounted for.

National Agency Check with Inquiries (NACI). The minimum Personnel Security Investigation (PSI) I requirements for a Contractor is a NACI. All positions within the USDA are assigned Position Sensitivity Designations (PSDs) based upon the risk/damage an unauthorized disclosure would cause to the Agency and/or national security. The COR will advise the Contractor of the assigned designation and investigative requirements at the kickoff meeting/at the onset of contract discussion. Based upon the assigned sensitivity designation, the minimum level PSI may not meet the requirements, and a higher level of investigation and/or security clearance may be required.

A list of all Contractor personnel assigned to this task with the dates and types of security background investigation checks completed will be submitted to the COR and contracting specialist prior to the initiation of any work effort charged against this SOW.